AN ACRONYM AND A COUNTER

AS THE RULING BJP'S 'BHARAT' MOVE CROSSES SWORDS WITH THE OPPOSITION'S 'INDIA' ALLIANCE, ALL EYES ARE ON THE BIG PRIZE—THE 2024 GENERAL ELECTION

By **KAUSHIK DEKA with ANILESH S. MAHAJAN**

On September 5, an invitation went out for an official G20 summit dinner hosted by President Droupadi Murmu where she was described as the 'President of Bharat' instead of the 'President of India'. The same day, a government leaflet on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the 20th summit of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) in Jakarta referred to him as the Prime Minister of Bharat. At the summit, too, he talked about Bharat's connect with Asia.

Even at the G20 summit, Modi sat behind a placard that read Bharat. A government booklet brought out for the event, titled 'Bharat—The Mother of Democracy', read: 'In Bharat that is India, the view or the will of the people in governance has been a central part of life since earliest recorded history.' This description was the inverse of what Article 1 of the Constitution states: 'India, that is Bharat, shall be a Union of States.'

These developments sparked off a war of words between the ruling BJP and Opposition parties amid speculation that the Centre was planning to change the official name of the country from India to Bharat. That the government has convened a special session of Parliament (September 18-22) without announcing the agenda added fuel to the speculation. Government sources, though, have dismissed such "rumours".

But the rumours had their roots in a narrative set by the leaders of the BJP and its ideological fountainhead, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS). The RSS has tagged the term Bharat into the title of many of its affiliates and two days before the president's dinner invite, its chief Mohan Bhagwat reiterated the same at a meeting in Guwahati. He called on the people to stop using the name India and switch to Bharat.

The Opposition leaders claim the recent emphasis of the saffron camp on using 'Bharat' to describe the country has been triggered by the formation of the 26-party anti-BJP alliance, INDIA (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance). "Maybe we irritated the government a little because we named our coalition INDIA and that got them all heated up. So now they've decided to change the name of the country," Congress leader Rahul Gandhi said in a video posted on social media.

The Opposition parties believe the BJP camp, with its ability to package and promote any message, has successfully used the emotional appeal of nationalism to build a narrative in which the saffron camp remains the sole custodian of national interest and its rivals are labelled anti-national. The proposal to call the alliance INDIA was a counter to such a narrative.

When Assam chief minister and BJP leader Himanta Biswa Sarma pooh-poohed the acronym, saying India was a name given by the British, team INDIA added a tagline, 'Jeetega Bharat', to blunt the attack. They also did not forget to remind the BJP that Rahul's five-month-long walkathon from Kanyakumari to Kashmir was called 'Bharat Jodo Yatra'.

The Opposition camp has carefully avoided taking a hos-